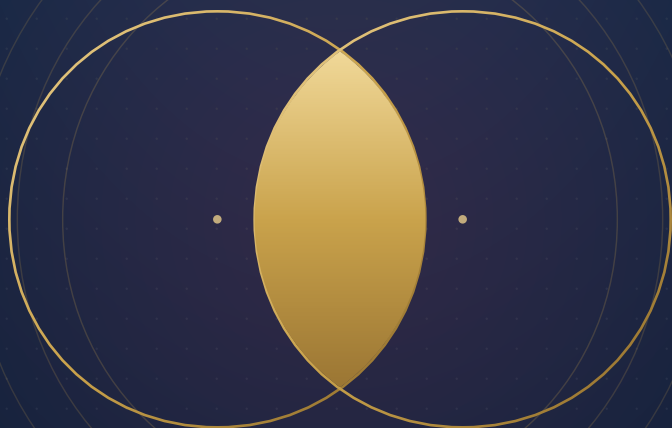


T H E

TRUST

ADVANTAGE

*The 8-Week Playbook to Master Communication
and Build Unshakeable Trust at Work*



CHRISTINE WALTER



THE TRUST ADVANTAGE

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and Build Unshakeable Trust at Work*

CHRISTINE WALTER, LMFT, PCC

Read a week. Practice a week. Build trust for life.

CORPORATE EDITION

The Trust Advantage

The 8-Week Playbook to Master Communication and Build Unshakeable Trust at Work

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This book is intended for educational and professional-development purposes. It is not a substitute for mental health treatment, legal advice, or individualized organizational consulting.

Sources for the research cited in this book appear in the References section, beginning on page 40. Digital Object Identifiers (DOIs) are provided where available; web addresses may change over time.

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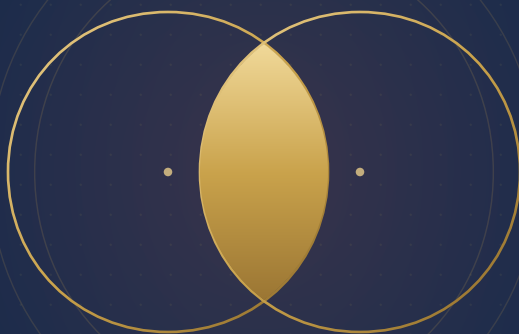
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PART ONE

Foundations

Why trust matters, how this playbook works, and the science behind every skill.

INTRODUCTION

Why Trust Is the Advantage

Every organization runs on two operating systems. The first is visible: strategy, structure, tools, and targets. The second is invisible, and it determines how well the first one works. It is trust.

When trust is high, information moves quickly. People flag problems while they are still small, disagree in the meeting instead of in the hallway, and give one another the benefit of the doubt when plans change. When trust is low, everything slows down. Messages are softened, rewritten, and copied to more people. Bad news arrives late. Talented people spend their energy protecting themselves instead of solving problems.

The difference shows up in the data. In a large survey of employees across many companies, neuroeconomist Paul Zak found that people at high-trust companies reported 74 percent less stress, 106 percent more energy at work, 50 percent higher productivity, and 40 percent less burnout than people at low-trust companies (Zak, 2017). When Google studied more than 180 of its own teams, the most important of the five dynamics that set effective teams apart was psychological safety, a close cousin of trust (Google re:Work, n.d.; Duhigg, 2016).



Self-reported by employees at high-trust versus low-trust companies (Zak, 2017)

Here is the good news, and the premise of this book: trust is not a personality trait you either have or lack. It is the predictable result of specific, learnable behaviors: how you open a conversation, how you listen,

how you react to bad news, how you deliver hard feedback, and how you repair a mistake. Those behaviors can be practiced. Practiced consistently, they compound.

This playbook gives you eight of them, one per week, each grounded in research and translated into daily drills you can use in your next meeting. It is written for individual contributors and executives alike, because trust is built the same way at every level: one interaction at a time.

READ THIS FIRST

How to Use This Playbook

Most books on communication fail for one reason: you read them, feel inspired, and change nothing. This playbook is built to prevent that. It is a training program, not a lecture.

- ◆ **One week, one skill.** Read the chapter (about 20 minutes), then spend the rest of the week practicing the skill in real conversations at work.
- ◆ **Practice beats theory.** You will not master listening by reading about it. You master it by listening, imperfectly, ten times, until it becomes natural.
- ◆ **Score yourself honestly.** Every week ends with a Mastery Check. You are not done with a week until you can honestly check every box. If you can't yet, repeat the week; there is no prize for finishing early.
- ◆ **Return to it often.** The one-page cheat sheet on page 37 is designed to be printed, pinned up, and used daily.
- ◆ **Bring your team.** The facilitation guide on page 39 shows how to run all eight weeks as a group program in 30 minutes a week.

THE CORE PROMISE

Trust is not a mystery or a fixed personality trait. It is shaped by learnable behaviors. Practice these eight skills consistently and you will become easier to trust: at work, at home, and in the relationships that matter most.

— HOW EACH WEEK IS BUILT

The One Thing to Remember	The single idea to carry with you all week.
The Big Idea & Why It Works	The concept, and the research behind it.
The Skills	Specific, observable behaviors you can use today.
Your 7-Day Practice	One drill per day, in real conversations.
Mastery Check & Common Traps	The standard to meet, and the mistakes to avoid.
Team Conversation	Two questions for discussing the skill with colleagues.

— THE EIGHT WEEKS AT A GLANCE

1	Warmth First	Lead with good intent before credentials.
2	Listen So They Feel Heard	Ask questions that deepen understanding.
3	Make It Safe to Speak	Make honesty, and bad news, feel safe.
4	Turn Toward the Small Moments	Respond to small bids for connection.
5	Say the Hard Thing Kindly	Give feedback that is clear and caring.
6	Presence: The Body Speaks First	Align your posture, face, and voice with your intent.
7	Influence Without Manipulation	Persuade in ways that serve both sides.
8	Repair, Rebuild, Repeat	Apologize well and rebuild trust over time.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Your Two-Minute Trust Baseline

Before Week 1, score yourself on each statement from 1 (rarely true) to 5 (consistently true). Don't try to look good on paper; the point is to notice what changes over eight weeks. For a sharper read, ask a colleague you trust to score you as well.

STATEMENT	BEFORE WEEK 1	AFTER WEEK 8
People bring me bad news early.		
I listen without immediately fixing or hijacking the conversation.		
I can be direct without making people feel diminished.		
My body language matches the calm and openness I want to create.		
I keep small promises reliably.		
When I make a mistake, I repair it quickly and specifically.		
Total (out of 30)		

Retake this assessment after Week 8. The goal is not perfection; it is greater consistency under real pressure.

The Science in Five Minutes

Before you practice anything, understand the four findings that make this playbook work. Every skill in this book traces back to at least one of them.

1 People judge you on two dimensions, and warmth comes first.

Decades of cross-cultural research show that when we meet someone, we answer two questions: *Are your intentions toward me good?* (warmth) and *Are you able to act on them?* (competence). Warmth judgments tend to come first and carry more weight (Fiske et al., 2007). In organizations, these two dimensions shape who gets hired, evaluated favorably, mentored, and promoted (Cuddy et al., 2011). Leading with warmth is not softness. It is strategy.

2 Psychological safety is the foundation of team effectiveness.

Google's Project Aristotle studied more than 180 of its own teams to learn what separates great teams from the rest. Who was on the team mattered less than how the team worked together, and the most important factor was psychological safety: the shared belief that you can take an interpersonal risk without being punished or humiliated (Google re:Work, n.d.; Duhigg, 2016).

3 Real communication is a measurable sync between two brains.

Princeton neuroscientists recorded the brain activity of a person telling a story and of people listening to it. When communication succeeded, the listeners' brain activity became closely aligned with the speaker's, a phenomenon called *neural coupling*. When communication failed, the coupling disappeared, and the stronger the coupling, the better the listener understood the story (Stephens et al., 2010). Great listening isn't passive. It is the active work of getting on the same wavelength.

4 Trust is built in small moments, not grand gestures.

Psychologist John Gottman followed newlywed couples for six years. Couples who stayed together had turned toward each other's small "bids for connection" 86 percent of the time; couples who later divorced had done so only 33 percent of the time (Gottman Institute, n.d.). Trust compounds, or decays, one small moment at a time. That is as true in the conference room as it is at the dinner table.

THE TAKEAWAY

Warmth first. Safety always. Listen to connect. Turn toward the small stuff. Everything else is detail.

The Trust Equation

In *The Trusted Advisor*, David Maister, Charles Green, and Robert Galford introduced a deceptively simple formula that explains why some brilliant people are never fully trusted, while some quiet people are trusted completely (Maister et al., 2000).

$$\text{Trust} = \frac{\text{Credibility} + \text{Reliability} + \text{Intimacy}}{\text{Self-Orientation}}$$

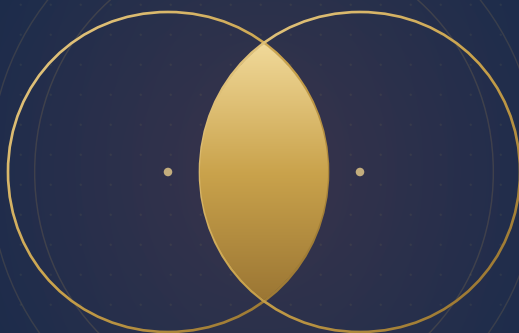
Credibility	“I believe what you say.” Your expertise and honesty.
Reliability	“I can count on what you do.” You keep promises.
Intimacy	“I feel safe sharing with you.” Safety and discretion.
Self-Orientation	The denominator, and the trust killer. It is the degree to which you make an interaction about you: your image, your agenda, your need to be right.

Here is the insight that changes careers: the fastest way to increase trust is often not to add more credibility or reliability. It is to reduce self-orientation. Because self-orientation divides everything above it, even a modest rise can cancel out years of expertise and good work.

The equation maps closely onto the academic research, which finds that trust rests on three perceptions of another person: their ability, their benevolence, and their integrity (Mayer et al., 1995; Lewicki & Brinsfield, 2017).

KEEP IT IN MIND

Every skill you are about to learn either lowers your self-orientation or raises one of the three factors above the line.



PART TWO

The Eight Weeks

One skill per week. Seven drills per skill. A clear standard for mastery.

01



WEEK ONE

Warmth First: Win the First Four Seconds

THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

People decide whether to trust you before they decide whether to respect you. Lead with warmth; let competence follow.

— THE BIG IDEA

You have probably been told that at work you must “prove yourself” first. The research suggests the opposite. When two people meet, the brain answers “friend or foe?” before it answers “capable or not?” (Fiske et al., 2007). Those impressions form remarkably fast. In one set of experiments, people judged a stranger’s trustworthiness from a face after seeing it for just one-tenth of a second, and more time mostly made them more confident in the judgment they had already made (Willis & Todorov, 2006).

Lead with competence, and you may never get the chance to show warmth. Lead with warmth, and your competence lands with more force.

— WHY IT WORKS

The warmth-competence framework has been tested across cultures and applied directly to the workplace, where it helps explain hiring decisions, performance evaluations, mentoring, and promotion (Cuddy et al., 2011). The lesson is not “be nice instead of smart.” It is this: *warmth is the gate; competence is the room behind it.*

— THE SKILLS

- 1 **The Warm Open.** In the first few seconds of an interaction, do four things: offer a genuine smile, the kind that reaches the eyes; make warm, steady eye contact; use the person's name; and ask one open question. This simple ritual signals good intent immediately.
- 2 **Signal Intent Before Ability.** Before you tell people what you can do, tell them what you want for them. “My goal is to make your week easier” lands better than “I have twelve years of experience.”
- 3 **Show Competence Through Generosity.** The most trusted experts give their knowledge away freely. Hoarding expertise reads as insecurity and raises self-orientation; sharing it reads as confidence.
- 4 **Soften the Resting Face.** People read trustworthiness from facial expressions almost instantly, and faces whose features subtly resemble a smile are judged more trustworthy than neutral or stern ones (Oosterhof & Todorov, 2008). An unintentionally stern or blank expression can read as cold. Notice your default expression in meetings and on video, and practice a relaxed, attentive face.

FIELD NOTE · GLOBAL TEAMS

Norms for eye contact, smiling, and first-name use vary across cultures. The principle, signaling good intent early, is universal. Adapt the specific behaviors to the person in front of you.

— YOUR 7-DAY PRACTICE

DAY	DRILL	DONE
1	Use the Warm Open with five people (a colleague, a client, the barista): name, smile, open question.	☐
2	Before every meeting, finish this sentence in writing: “What I want for this person today is...”	☐
3	Give away one piece of expertise for free, with no credit sought and no follow-up ask.	☐
4	Catch your resting face three times today and soften it.	☐
5	Open one conversation with your intent, not your credentials.	☐
6	Compliment someone’s effort or intent, not their status.	☐
7	<i>Review: Where did warmth open a door that competence alone would not have?</i>	☐

— MASTERY CHECK

- ☐ I can lead a first interaction with warmth without feeling fake.
- ☐ I state my intent before my qualifications.
- ☐ I notice a cold or closed expression on my face and soften it.

— COMMON TRAPS

The Brilliant Jerk. Competence with no warmth. Respected, perhaps, but never trusted.

The Credential Drop. Leading with your résumé instead of your intent.

The Neutral Mask. A blank face that others read as disapproval.

TEAM CONVERSATION

1. Think of a colleague you trusted quickly. What did they do in the first few minutes?
2. How do new team members experience their first week here: warm, neutral, or cold? What one change would shift it?

02



WEEK TWO

Listen So They Feel Heard

THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

The best listeners don't just stay quiet. They ask questions that make the other person feel interesting and understood.

THE BIG IDEA

Most people believe good listening means staying silent, nodding, and repeating back what was said. Research on 3,492 managers in a coaching-skills program suggests that is not enough. The people rated as the very best listeners, the top 5 percent, periodically asked questions that promoted discovery and insight, sometimes gently challenging assumptions in a constructive way (Zenger & Folkman, 2016).

Listening is not a pause in your talking. It is an active act of generosity.

WHY IT WORKS

When communication succeeds, the listener's brain activity aligns with the speaker's, and the stronger that alignment, the better the understanding (Stephens et al., 2010). High-quality listening also changes the speaker. Research by Guy Itzchakov and Avraham Kluger found that people who feel genuinely listened to become less anxious and defensive, more self-aware, and more willing to reflect on their own views (Itzchakov & Kluger, 2018). Listening is not only how you gather information. It is how you lower the other person's guard.

— THE SKILLS

- 1 **The Three Levels of Listening.** Adapted from the Co-Active coaching model (Kimsey-House et al., 2018). *Level 1, Internal:* you are mostly listening to your own thoughts, waiting to speak. *Level 2, Focused:* you are fully on their words. *Level 3, Global:* you are on their words, tone, and body language, and on what they are *not* saying. Aim for Level 3.
- 2 **The Three-Second Pause.** After someone finishes, wait three seconds before responding. It keeps you from hijacking the conversation and often lets the real point surface.
- 3 **“Tell Me More”.** Three simple words that deepen almost any conversation. When someone shares something, invite depth before jumping to a solution.
- 4 **Summarize for Accuracy, Not Approval.** “So the core of it is X. Did I get that right?” This proves you heard and invites correction.
- 5 **Listen to Understand, Not to Fix.** Most people want to be heard before they want to be helped. Offer solutions only after the other person feels understood.

FIELD NOTE · REMOTE TEAMS

On video calls, turn off self-view, close other tabs, and lengthen your pause slightly. Audio lag makes accidental interruptions more likely, and a beat of silence signals that you are still with them.

— YOUR 7-DAY PRACTICE

DAY	DRILL	DONE
1	In every conversation, use the Three-Second Pause. Count it silently.	☐
2	Say “Tell me more” at least three times today.	☐
3	Summarize one person’s point back to them before you respond.	☐
4	Catch yourself at Level 1 listening and return to Level 3.	☐
5	In one meeting, resist solving. Only seek to understand.	☐
6	Ask a follow-up question that helps someone think more clearly.	☐
7	<i>Review: Who opened up this week because you listened?</i>	☐

— MASTERY CHECK

- ☐ I pause before responding, as a habit.
- ☐ I ask questions that deepen the conversation rather than deflect it.
- ☐ I can summarize someone’s view so well that they say, “Exactly.”

— COMMON TRAPS

The Fixer. Jumps straight to solutions.

The Hijacker. “Oh, me too. That reminds me of...”

The Waiter. Silent, but clearly just waiting for a turn to speak.

TEAM CONVERSATION

1. When did you last feel truly heard at work? What did the other person do?
2. In our meetings, who gets interrupted most often, and what would change if they didn’t?

03



WEEK THREE

Make It Safe to Speak

THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

People rarely withhold the truth because they are dishonest. They withhold it because speaking up feels risky. Your job is to make it feel safe.

— THE BIG IDEA

Psychological safety, the shared belief that a team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking, was the most important of five dynamics Google found in its most effective teams (Google re:Work, n.d.). The concept was defined by Harvard's Amy Edmondson, whose landmark study of 51 work teams showed that psychological safety promotes learning behavior, which in turn drives performance (Edmondson, 1999).

Safety is not about being nice. It is about making it safe to be honest.

— WHY IT WORKS

Google found that people on teams with higher psychological safety were less likely to leave, more likely to draw on the diverse ideas of their teammates, brought in more revenue, and were rated as effective twice as often by executives (Google re:Work, n.d.). When people fear looking ignorant, incompetent, negative, or disruptive, they go quiet, and quiet teams fail slowly.

— THE SKILLS

- 1 **Leader Framing.** Open hard conversations by naming the stakes and lowering the risk: “We’re in this together. I may miss things, and I need you to catch what I can’t see.” Framing the work as a learning challenge rather than a test of performance is one of Edmondson’s core recommendations (Edmondson, 2018).
- 2 **Reward Bad News.** When someone brings you a problem, thank them first and solve second. Your reaction to the first piece of bad news determines whether you will hear the second.
- 3 **Separate the Person From the Idea.** Challenge the problem, never the person. “That approach carries a risk” beats “That’s a bad idea.”
- 4 **Climb the Question Ladder.** Move from closed questions (“Did it work?”) to open ones (“What did you notice?”) to genuinely curious ones (“What would have to be true for this to fail?”).
- 5 **Make It Normal Not to Know.** Say “I don’t know” out loud, and often. It gives everyone else permission to do the same.

— YOUR 7-DAY PRACTICE

DAY	DRILL	DONE
1	Open one meeting with a Leader Framing statement.	☐
2	Thank someone for bad news before responding to its content.	☐
3	Say “I don’t know” at least once, publicly and calmly.	☐
4	Practice the Question Ladder in one conversation.	☐
5	Reframe one criticism of a person into a critique of a problem.	☐
6	Ask a quiet colleague directly for their view, and then wait.	☐
7	<i>Review: Where did safety surface a truth you would not otherwise have heard?</i>	☐

— MASTERY CHECK

- ☐ People bring me problems early, not late.
- ☐ I respond to bad news with curiosity, not blame.
- ☐ I separate ideas from identities.

— COMMON TRAPS

The Messenger Shooter. Punishes whoever brings the bad news.

False Harmony. “We all agree!” when no one actually does.

Safety Theater. Claiming openness while quietly punishing dissent.

TEAM CONVERSATION

1. What is one thing that is hard to say on this team? Why?
2. How do we react the first time someone raises a problem, and what message does that send?

04



WEEK FOUR

Turn Toward the Small Moments

THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

Trust is not built in grand gestures. It is built in tiny bids for connection, and in the choice to turn toward them.

THE BIG IDEA

Psychologist John Gottman calls these small moments “bids for connection”: a comment, a sigh, a joke, a question. You can turn toward a bid, turn away from it, or turn against it. In his six-year study of newlyweds, couples who stayed together had turned toward each other’s bids 86 percent of the time; couples who later divorced had done so only 33 percent of the time (Gottman Institute, n.d.).

The same dynamic runs through every working relationship.

WHY IT WORKS

How you respond to someone’s good news matters as much as how you respond to their problems. Research by Shelly Gable and colleagues shows that *active-constructive responding*, meaning genuine, enthusiastic engagement with another person’s good news, is linked to greater relationship satisfaction and intimacy (Gable et al., 2004). Celebrating well is a trust skill.

— THE SKILLS

- 1 **Notice the Bid.** A bid is often small and indirect: “Busy day, huh?” or “I finally fixed that bug.” Train yourself to hear it as a request for connection.
- 2 **Respond Active-Constructively.** Not passively (“Cool.”) and not destructively (“That’s nothing”). Actively: “That’s great. How did you crack it? Tell me.”
- 3 **Celebrate Louder Than You Criticize.** Most people over-respond to problems and under-respond to wins. Flip the ratio.
- 4 **The 20-Second Connection.** Twenty seconds of genuine attention, with no phone and full eye contact, beats a distracted hour.
- 5 **Repair Fast.** If you turn away, name it and come back: “Sorry, I wasn’t really listening. Say that again?”

FIELD NOTE · REMOTE TEAMS

Bids are easy to miss in chat. A teammate’s “Finally shipped it!” in a team channel is a bid. A specific, personal reply does far more than a quick reaction icon.

— YOUR 7-DAY PRACTICE

DAY	DRILL	DONE
1	Count how many bids you notice today. Aim for awareness first.	☐
2	Respond active-constructively to three people's good news.	☐
3	Give one person a full 20-second connection with zero distraction.	☐
4	Turn toward a bid you would normally ignore.	☐
5	Repair one "turn away" by naming it.	☐
6	Celebrate someone's small win more than their small mistake.	☐
7	<i>Review: Whose trust deepened because you showed up in a small moment?</i>	☐

— MASTERY CHECK

- ☐ I notice bids for connection in real time.
- ☐ I respond to good news with real enthusiasm.
- ☐ I repair quickly when I turn away.

— COMMON TRAPS

Passive-Constructive. "Nice." The trust killer that looks harmless.

Phone-Splitting. Giving someone half your attention.

Big-Win-Only Enthusiasm. Celebrating only the dramatic.

TEAM CONVERSATION

1. What small wins happened on this team this week that nobody acknowledged?
2. How do we respond to each other's good news in our team channels?

05



WEEK FIVE

Say the Hard Thing Kindly

THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

Vague niceness feels safe but erodes trust. Specific honesty, delivered with care, builds it.

THE BIG IDEA

People trust those who tell them the truth and clearly have their back. Feedback is not the opposite of kindness; it is a form of it. The goal is to be clear and caring at the same time.

Avoiding a hard conversation is not generosity. It is a slow withdrawal of trust.

WHY IT WORKS

How you praise shapes how people handle difficulty. In a series of studies, Claudia Mueller and Carol Dweck found that children praised for their intelligence were more likely to avoid challenges, and to persist less and perform worse after a setback, than children praised for their effort (Mueller & Dweck, 1998). Later research found that the share of process praise toddlers heard from their parents predicted their beliefs about effort and ability five years later (Gunderson et al., 2013).

These studies were conducted with children, but the principle is a useful guide for adults: praise what people *do*, not who they *are*, and you reward the behavior you want repeated.

— THE SKILLS

- 1 **The SBI Model.** Situation → Behavior → Impact, a feedback framework developed by the Center for Creative Leadership. “In yesterday’s meeting (situation), you cut off the client mid-sentence (behavior), and I think it cost us some of her trust (impact).” Facts first, no labels.
- 2 **Praise the Process.** Replace “You’re so smart” with “The way you broke that problem down was excellent.” You reward what you want repeated.
- 3 **Ask Permission.** “Can I share an observation?” turns a verdict into a conversation.
- 4 **Feedforward, Not Just Feedback.** Spend more time on what to do next than on what went wrong. Executive coach Marshall Goldsmith calls this *feedforward*.
- 5 **The 2:1 Caring Ratio.** A practical rule of thumb: in a hard conversation, make sure the other person feels your support at least twice as strongly as your critique.
- 6 **“What Would Great Look Like?”** Invite the other person to design the fix. People are more committed to solutions they help create.

— YOUR 7-DAY PRACTICE

DAY	DRILL	DONE
1	Use SBI to give one piece of clean, factual feedback.	☐
2	Praise one person's process, not their talent.	☐
3	Ask permission before sharing an observation.	☐
4	Turn one criticism into a feedforward suggestion.	☐
5	Ask "What would great look like?" in one conversation.	☐
6	Have the hard conversation you have been avoiding, kindly.	☐
7	<i>Review: Did honesty deepen or damage trust? Why?</i>	☐

— MASTERY CHECK

- ☐ I give feedback that is specific and behavior-based.
- ☐ I praise effort and strategy, not fixed traits.
- ☐ I can be honest without being harsh.

— COMMON TRAPS

The Feedback Sandwich. Burying the real point between two compliments.

Talent Praise. Labels like "natural" or "genius" that leave people fragile when they fail.

Conflict Avoidance. Silent resentment that eventually leaks.

TEAM CONVERSATION

1. What feedback have you received that genuinely helped you? What made it work?
2. Is there a conversation on this team that we keep postponing?

06



WEEK SIX

Presence: The Body Speaks First

THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

Your body sets the emotional tone of a conversation before your first sentence lands.

THE BIG IDEA

Long before you choose your words, your posture, face, and voice signal whether you are safe to be around. Rapport is partly physical: people in a good conversation tend to fall into a shared rhythm, and that coordination is part of what connection feels like.

WHY IT WORKS

Classic experiments found that people who were subtly mimicked liked their partner more and felt the interaction went more smoothly (Chartrand & Bargh, 1999). More recent and more rigorous work adds an important caveat: in a pre-registered virtual-reality study, mimicry on its own did not reliably increase rapport or trust (Hale & Hamilton, 2016). What holds up better is broader coordination. When two people naturally fall into sync in their movement and timing, they tend to report higher rapport (Fujiwara et al., 2026).

The practical lesson: align with someone's overall rhythm and energy rather than copying their gestures. Presence is not decoration. It is part of the foundation of trust.

— THE SKILLS

- 1 **Match, Don't Mimic.** Align subtly with the other person's pace, energy, and overall posture. Never copy specific gestures; that reads as mockery. Match the rhythm, not the moves.
- 2 **Open Body.** Uncrossed arms, visible hands, and a body angled toward the person. Closed postures can signal defensiveness.
- 3 **The Calm Voice.** Manage pace (slow down), pitch (lower it slightly), and pause (let silence do some of the work). A steady voice helps steady the room.
- 4 **Regulate Yourself First.** Before a hard conversation, try box breathing: in for four counts, hold for four, out for four, hold for four. It is hard to calm someone else when you are not calm yourself.
- 5 **Read Clusters, Not Cues.** One crossed arm means nothing; the room might simply be cold. Look for patterns: posture, tone, and words together.

FIELD NOTE · VIDEO PRESENCE

Set your camera at eye level, look into the lens when you make a key point, keep your hands visible when you gesture, and light your face from the front. On video, your face is most of your body language.

— YOUR 7-DAY PRACTICE

DAY	DRILL	DONE
1	In three conversations, subtly match the other person's rhythm.	☐
2	Practice an open posture in every meeting today.	☐
3	Slow your speech by about 20 percent and add pauses.	☐
4	Use box breathing before one difficult conversation.	☐
5	Notice one person's cluster of nonverbal cues.	☐
6	Lower and steady your voice in a tense moment.	☐
7	<i>Review: When did your body change the temperature of a room?</i>	☐

— MASTERY CHECK

- ☐ I naturally match rhythm without mimicking.
- ☐ My default posture is open and approachable.
- ☐ I can calm my own body before a hard conversation.

— COMMON TRAPS

Fake Mirroring. Obvious, and off-putting.

Closed Posture. Crossed arms, a phone in hand, a body turned away.

Single-Cue Over-Reading. Treating one signal as the whole story.

TEAM CONVERSATION

1. How does the energy in our meetings change when the most senior person is stressed?
2. What are our video-call habits signaling to each other?



Influence Without Manipulation

THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

Ethical influence is not making people do what you want. It is helping them see why it serves them too.

— THE BIG IDEA

The difference between influence and manipulation is intent. Influence serves both people; manipulation serves only you. Robert Cialdini's research identifies principles of persuasion that people respond to widely: reciprocity, commitment and consistency, social proof, authority, liking, and scarcity, with a seventh, unity, added in his later work (Cialdini, 2021).

Used honestly, these principles accelerate trust. Used dishonestly, they destroy it.

— WHY IT WORKS

The norm of reciprocity, the expectation that we repay what others give us, is one of the most powerful and pervasive social forces across human cultures (Cialdini & Goldstein, 2004). Giving first creates a natural pull toward mutual trust. In negotiation, the classic advice still holds: focus on interests, not positions, and always know your BATNA (your best alternative to a negotiated agreement), because it is a central source of leverage (Fisher et al., 2011).

— THE SKILLS

- 1 **Give First.** Genuine, unrequested generosity, such as information, help, or credit, creates reciprocal trust.
- 2 **Find the Shared Interest.** Ask, “What does success look like for you?” Then build a path to it.
- 3 **Use the “Because”.** Giving a reason increases cooperation, especially for modest requests. In a classic study, people were more willing to let someone cut ahead at a copy machine when the request included a reason (Langer et al., 1978). Always give the why.
- 4 **Commit Publicly, Deliver Consistently.** Make small, visible commitments and keep them. Consistency compounds trust.
- 5 **Label and Calibrate.** Name the other person’s emotion (“It sounds like you’re worried this will slip”), then ask a calibrated, open-ended question (“How would you like me to handle that?”). These techniques were popularized by former FBI hostage negotiator Chris Voss (Voss & Raz, 2016).
- 6 **Use Honest Social Proof.** Show what others have done, but only if it is true. Fabricated proof is a time bomb.

— YOUR 7-DAY PRACTICE

DAY	DRILL	DONE
1	Give something of value with no ask attached.	☐
2	In one conversation, ask, “What does success look like for you?”	☐
3	Add a “because” to every request you make today.	☐
4	Make one public commitment and keep it the same day.	☐
5	Label someone’s emotion and follow with a calibrated question.	☐
6	Cite honest social proof to support one idea.	☐
7	<i>Review: Did your influence feel like partnership or pressure?</i>	☐

— MASTERY CHECK

- ☐ I give before I ask, genuinely.
- ☐ I negotiate interests, not positions.
- ☐ My influence leaves people feeling served, not used.

— COMMON TRAPS

Manipulation. A short-term win and a long-term loss.

Scarcity Abuse. Manufactured urgency and pressure.

Feature-Dumping. Leading with what you want instead of what they need.

TEAM CONVERSATION

1. Where do we rely on authority (“because I said so”) when a real “because” would work better?
2. What would a genuine win-win look like in our next cross-team negotiation?

08



WEEK EIGHT

Repair, Rebuild, Repeat

THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

Trust is not built by never failing. It is built by repairing well when you do.

THE BIG IDEA

Every relationship breaks at some point. The difference between people who are trusted for a lifetime and those who are not is not the absence of mistakes. It is the skill of repair. A well-handled rupture can even leave trust stronger than before, because it proves the relationship can survive reality.

WHY IT WORKS

Trust rests on three judgments: *ability* (Can you do it?), *benevolence* (Do you care about me?), and *integrity* (Are you honest?) (Mayer et al., 1995; Lewicki & Brinsfield, 2017). Not all apologies are equal. In two experiments with 755 participants, apologies that contained more components were rated as more effective, and two components mattered most: acknowledging responsibility and offering to repair the damage (Lewicki et al., 2016).

The type of violation matters, too. An apology that takes ownership is effective at repairing a competence-based violation, while integrity-based violations are much harder to repair with words alone (Kim et al., 2004). They call for proof over time.

— THE SKILLS

- 1 **The Six-Part Apology.** Research identifies six components of an effective apology (Lewicki et al., 2016), listed here in order of impact:

(1) **Acknowledge responsibility:** “I was wrong,” with no excuses. (2) **Offer repair:** “Here’s how I’ll make it right.” (3) **Explain** what happened, briefly and without deflecting. (4) **Express regret** for the impact on the other person. (5) **Declare repentance:** “Here’s what I’m changing so it doesn’t happen again.” (6) **Request forgiveness**, and then stop talking.

If you remember nothing else, own it and offer to fix it.

- 2 **Match the Repair to the Violation.** Broke a promise (reliability)? Show consistency over time. Missed something (competence)? Show the fix. Lied (integrity)? Only repeated, verifiable honesty rebuilds it.
- 3 **Prove It, Don’t Just Say It.** Words start repair; behavior finishes it. Trust is rebuilt through a track record, not a speech.
- 4 **Rebuild on a Timeline.** Expect trust to return in small increments. Be patient and consistent, and don’t demand instant forgiveness.
- 5 **Forgive Yourself.** Shame makes people defensive and withdrawn, the two states that most block repair. Own it, fix it, and move forward.

— YOUR 7-DAY PRACTICE

DAY	DRILL	DONE
1	Write out a six-part apology for a real situation.	☐
2	Deliver one genuine, complete apology, and then stop talking.	☐
3	Identify whether a recent violation was about ability, benevolence, or integrity.	☐
4	Take one concrete action that proves the repair.	☐
5	Keep a promise you would normally let slide.	☐
6	Practice patience: let trust rebuild without demanding it.	☐
7	<i>Review all eight weeks: Which habit changed your relationships most?</i>	☐

— MASTERY CHECK

- ☐ I can apologize fully, without excuses.
- ☐ I repair with behavior, not just words.
- ☐ I rebuild trust patiently, one consistent act at a time.

— COMMON TRAPS

The “Sorry If”. “I’m sorry if you were offended.” A non-apology.

Blame-Shifting. “I only did it because...”

Rushed Repair. Demanding trust back on your own schedule.

TEAM CONVERSATION

1. How does this team handle mistakes: are they hidden, punished, or learned from?
2. What would a blameless review of our last miss look like?

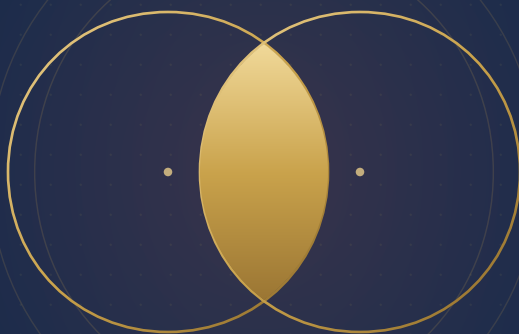
A Final Practice

Trust is not a performance. It is the accumulation of what people repeatedly experience around you: your attention, your reliability, your honesty, your ability to make room for the truth, and your willingness to repair what you get wrong.

Choose one habit from this book and make it visible today.

Then return to your Trust Baseline on page 6 and score yourself again. Notice what has changed, and notice where you still have room to grow. That gap is not a failure. It is your next eight weeks.

*The work is small.
The effect compounds.*



PART THREE

The Toolkit

Print these pages. Pin them up. Use them for the rest of your career.

The 12 Trust Habits

1	Warmth first. Smile, name, eye contact, open question, then credentials.	WEEK 1
2	Intent before ability. Tell people what you want for them.	WEEK 1
3	Pause three seconds before responding.	WEEK 2
4	“Tell me more.” Ask questions that help people think.	WEEK 2
5	Thank bad news first; solve second.	WEEK 3
6	Say “I don’t know” out loud.	WEEK 3
7	Turn toward the small bids. Notice them and respond.	WEEK 4
8	Celebrate loudly; criticize quietly.	WEEK 4
9	Praise process, not talent. Be specific and kind.	WEEK 5
10	Open body, calm voice. Regulate yourself first.	WEEK 6
11	Give before you ask. Negotiate interests, not positions.	WEEK 7
12	Repair fast and fully. Behavior finishes what words start.	WEEK 8

IF YOU REMEMBER NOTHING ELSE

Lower your self-orientation. Every habit above is a way of making the other person, not yourself, the center of the moment. That, more than any technique, is what trust is made of.

WORKSHEET

Your 8-Week Mastery Tracker

WEEK	SKILL	CONFIDENCE (1-5)	ONE WIN THIS WEEK
1	Warmth First		
2	Listen So They Feel Heard		
3	Make It Safe to Speak		
4	Turn Toward the Small Moments		
5	Say the Hard Thing Kindly		
6	Presence: The Body Speaks First		
7	Influence Without Manipulation		
8	Repair, Rebuild, Repeat		

AFTER EIGHT WEEKS

Reread the cheat sheet monthly. Rerun the tracker quarterly. Mastery is maintenance, not a finish line.

Running It With Your Team

Trust is a team sport. This playbook works for individuals, but it works faster when a whole team practices together, because everyone is building the same habits and can recognize them in one another.

— THE 30-MINUTE WEEKLY HUDDLE

0-5 min	Check in. Each person shares one moment from last week when they used, or missed, the skill.
5-15 min	The idea. One person, rotating weekly, summarizes the chapter's Big Idea and One Thing to Remember in two minutes. The group discusses.
15-25 min	Team Conversation. Work through the two questions at the end of the chapter.
25-30 min	Commit. Each person names, out loud, one drill they will do this week. (That is Week 7's "commit publicly" in action.)

— GROUND RULES

- ◆ What is shared in the huddle stays in the huddle.
- ◆ Speak from your own experience, not about absent colleagues.
- ◆ The most senior person goes first on the hard questions.
- ◆ No one is graded. The baseline and tracker are private unless people choose to share them.

A NOTE FOR LEADERS

Model it first. Your team will watch how you respond the first time someone admits a miss in the huddle. That moment will teach more than this entire book.

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KEEP GOING

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Christine Walter is a Licensed Marriage and Family Therapist (LMFT) and a Professional Certified Coach (PCC). Her work brings together two disciplines: the clinical understanding of how relationships work, and the coaching craft of how people change. *The Trust Advantage* distills both into a practical, research-grounded program for building trust at work.

THE TRUST ADVANTAGE

Talent gets you in the room. Trust is what makes the room work.

When trust is high, bad news travels early, disagreement happens in the meeting instead of the hallway, and great people stay. When it is low, everything slows down. *The Trust Advantage* turns decades of research on psychological safety, listening, feedback, influence, and repair into an eight-week training program: one skill per week, seven daily drills, and a clear standard for mastery.

INSIDE, YOU WILL LEARN HOW TO

- ◆ Lead with warmth and win the first moments of any interaction
- ◆ Listen in a way that lowers defenses and surfaces the real issue
- ◆ Build a team where people raise problems early
- ◆ Deliver hard feedback that people actually act on
- ◆ Influence without pressure or manipulation
- ◆ Repair broken trust with an apology grounded in research

Christine Walter, LMFT, PCC, is a licensed marriage and family therapist and professional certified coach. She brings clinical insight into how relationships work, and coaching expertise in how people change, to the challenge of building trust at work.

Read a week. Practice a week. Build trust for life.

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